

Episode 57: Once Upon a Time... (38) – Remembering and Thinking About *My Youth in Arcadia* Part-Time Job Story

Sorry for taking a two-week break from serialisation. Various deadlines and other things in my main work kept me from having time to write manuscripts properly. Sorry to everyone who looks forward to this.

That's right! When I think about it, the other writers for this Anime Style—aside from me, they're all writers or artists, people whose job is writing (drawing)! Since I'm fundamentally a "colour" person, I don't write or draw that much.

...Well, that's a bit of an excuse (laugh).

I might have to take breaks like this again in the future, but I'm back starting this week. Alright, let's work hard (distant look).

Well then.

A while ago I bought a DVD of a nostalgic work, and while I'd been carrying it around in my bag everywhere, I finally got to watch it recently.

The theatrical work *My Youth in Arcadia* (わが青春のアルカディア). Original by Matsumoto Leiji, director Katsumata Tomoharu, character design & animation director Komatsubara Kazuo, art director Ito Iwamitsu. A 1982 Toei Doga work.

This work was released during the summer vacation of the year I started part-time finishing work, so I had some memories of it. So this week, going back quite a bit in time, is the story of my part-time job days.

"Well, there's some work I'd like you to handle..."

One day in June or July of that year, I was called by the president of the finishing production company "Kozue Anime" where I worked part-time.

"I'd like you to handle this"

When I went to the studio (or rather, workshop) in West Ikebukuro, there were some thick, large-format cuts on the glass reception table. The cut bag had "*My Youth in Arcadia*" written on it. "Oh! Theatrical work!" I thought. Actually, since I'd only recently started part-time work, I hadn't been allowed to do colouring work on theatrical productions yet.

"I want you to paint these flame cels"

The president took animation drawings from the cut bag. The animation size was over 230 frames, large-format animation. About A2 size? What was drawn on that animation paper were thin flames running in wavy patterns. Basic two-colour painting, with 1-2 flames running per animation drawing. With cel layers going up to about ABCDEF.

I heard these were cuts from prominence or something that appeared in the story's climax. There were several cuts like this, apparently divided among several Toei-affiliated finishing companies at the time.

So the "Kozue Anime" portion of flame cuts was to be painted by me and senior S-tasan.

In today's digital colouring era, to put it roughly, there's honestly almost no difference in finished quality between TV and theatrical work based on the painter's skill level, but in the cel colouring era, whether tracing or colouring, technical skill differences showed up clearly in the finished results.

So at "Kozue Anime" at the time, only veteran in-house staff and some freelance staff could handle theatrical work colouring. There were several freelance staff who could finish tonnes of frames, but they were at "TV work quality" colouring level, so in principle such people couldn't be given theatrical work.

Writing this might make TV work seem low-level, but "Kozue Anime's" colouring level was actually quite high (I realised this even more after joining Toei Doga and seeing finished cels from other Toei-affiliated finishing companies).

"This is colour tracing, right?" I asked.

In cel finishing, pencil-drawn animation is carbon-transferred to cels using trace machines, but so-called "colour trace" artwork can't be transferred by trace machines, so you trace the animation artwork placed underneath directly onto cels with pens.

At the time, cel finishing workflows often separated "hand tracing" and "colouring" workers, but "Kozue Anime" deliberately didn't separate workers, with the policy that "the person painting does all the tracing too." So I thought we'd do all the colour tracing for these "flame cuts" too.

But as I wrote earlier, I was still a newcomer who'd just started. Would a newcomer's tracing skill be adequate for theatrical work?

"You don't need to trace this"

"Huh?"

"Paint directly"

"What? (sweat)"

That's right. Normally you'd first colour trace from the front, then flip the cel and paint, but this time we'd skip colour tracing and paint directly from the back while tracing the animation.

"The finishing desks are occupied and it's large format, so paint here" - the president pointed to the reception table!

And the battle began that night.

We fixed a Z-light to the glass reception table, lit from below to create a "makeshift large-format light table," and on that we used animation pegs, paper clips, and scotch tape to fix animation and cels so they wouldn't shift, carefully painting with brushes. Two colours: B-3 (red) and OR-3 (orange). Brushes were industry-standard Sable long brushes. Fortunately they were relatively easy-to-paint colours, so we thinned the paint as much as possible and spread it evenly across the cels.

At first I was nervous and painted very slowly, but gradually getting the hang of it, I became more skilled and got into a good pace. Conversations with senior S-san and other staff were fun, almost like preparing for a school festival (laugh).

Time passed and the clock went past midnight. I was making mistakes left and right from familiarity and drowsiness (bitter laugh). Starting to paint without flipping the animation paper, or dozing off and painting strange places (bitter laugh). We worked until morning and withdrew once. The tiny company "Kozue Anime" had a narrow workspace, so work was difficult with many people coming and going during the day, plus I was a student so I went to classes during the day (laugh). So I returned to the company in the evening and resumed work.

How many frames were there total? I don't remember anymore, but since we worked two nights together, there were quite a few frames. I remember getting 500 yen per frame at the time.

Over 20 years have passed since then (laugh).

Looking back, this experience might have been one of the triggers for me ending up in this anime-making job (laugh). Incidentally, the S-senior who painted with me is now active in key animation and direction. Recently he was one of the character designers for *Itazura na Kiss*.

Now, for this *My Youth in Arcadia*, I think I went to see it when it was released, but I completely forgot the content, so rewatching on DVD I was a bit surprised like "Ah, so this was the story!" Hmm, it was a subtle work (bitter laugh), and long too (130 minutes runtime).

But I could watch it nostalgically thinking "This was the 'mood' of Toei theatrical works back then." I was satisfied watching the flame cel scenes we painted with a bit of happiness (laugh).

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